Session 14. Reading Sheet: The Mark of a Criminal Record

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Wednesday, October 14, 2026

Read before class. Write a sentence or two for each question. We will open the workshop with your answers.

Reading: Pager, Devah. 2003. "The Mark of a Criminal Record." *American Journal of Sociology* 108(5): 937–975. Also skim: Kline, Patrick M., Evan K. Rose, and Christopher R. Walters. 2022. "Systemic Discrimination Among Large U.S. Employers." *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 137(4): 1963–2036 (free working paper: NBER 29053).

Questions for Today

- What comparison would allow us to measure employment discrimination?
- What does an audit experiment hold constant? What does it change?
- What does the research design allow us to say?
- How certain are we about the result?
- Does a result from Milwaukee in 2001 travel to other places, people, jobs, employers, and times?
- What do we learn when the same basic design is used for more than 83,000 applications?

Does a Criminal Record Reduce the Chance of a Callback?

Pager wanted to know how a criminal record affects employment opportunities. She also wanted to know whether the effect was the same for Black and white applicants.

1. Why is that question difficult to answer using ordinary employment records?
2. What might differ between people with and without criminal records besides the record itself?

Pager's Audit Experiment

Pager hired two pairs of men to apply for entry-level jobs in Milwaukee. One pair was Black and one pair was white. The testers were matched within each pair on physical appearance and self-presentation.

Within each pair, Pager randomly varied which tester reported a felony drug conviction. The pair alternated which applicant presented the criminal record each week.

3. What is the treatment?
4. What is the outcome?
5. What was randomized? What was not randomized?
6. What comparison identifies the effect of a criminal record among white applicants? What comparison identifies it among Black applicants?
7. Can we identify the effect of race in exactly the same way? Why or why not?

What Does a Callback Measure?

The outcome is whether an employer called the tester back after the application.

8. Does a callback measure whether someone was hired? Does it measure how the employer would treat the person after hiring? Does it tell us why the employer made the decision?
9. What part of employment discrimination can this outcome reveal?

What Pattern Do You Expect?

Write down the expected ordering before we calculate anything.

10. Which group should have the highest callback rate? Which should have the lowest?
11. If criminal records matter, what should we observe within each race? If race matters, what should we observe within each criminal-record group?